

HAM to the rescue

The recent power outage crisis that swept across the eastern United States also put the high-tech communication links used by emergency services in a quandary. It was up to the HAM radio enthusiasts to keep the police services, fire fighters, Red Cross officials and other workers connected in what is now defined as the US's most extensive power outage since 1977. With battery backups and no need for servers and cell



phone towers, American Radio Relay League (ARRL) volunteers were in contact with the Red Cross and the Office of Emergency Management, within five minutes of the power going down. The volunteers, for instance, connected one hospital to its ambulance fleet as it went out of power. Officials estimate that between 800-1000 ARRL volunteers were handling communications on the 15th and 16th of last month, till power was restored.

Wi-Fi traffic jam

Researchers at the Centre Nationale de la Recherche Scientifique (CNRS), Paris, claim to have found a critical flaw in wireless LAN technology used for Internet hot-spots that could cause a slow user accessing the network to slow down everyone connected to the same access point. The problem lies with the CSMA/CA (Carrier Sense Multiple Access/Collision Avoidance) access protocol that is supposed to grant equal access to the hot spot by all connected devices. This means that users capable of higher speed will get only as much bandwidth as the slowest user.

This will not be apparent to most Web surfers though. The speed bottleneck whilst accessing the Internet through wireless LAN is usually not due to the LAN, but the actual Internet connectivity supporting the LAN. Considering this, the 1 MB limitation shouldn't be too restrictive. But users accessing large files within the LAN will definitely feel the pinch.

Txt-a-flop

Ignoring the the fact that the current multi-million dollar movie lack originality or just fail to impress, industry pundits have a new explanation for the nose-diving ticket sales. And if you would believe the movie makers, the blame is being placed on teenagers, who send their friends text messages via cell phone with their verdict on the movie. These messages spread at an alarming pace causing higher rates of average

audience drop-off—the number of less viewers in the subsequent week.

Five years ago, the average drop-off between the opening weekend and the next weekend was 40 per cent. Movie makers point out that this summer's average is 51 per cent and drop-off effects are visible on the second day after opening. A good example is *Terminator 3: Rise of the Machines* that witnessed a 56 per cent drop over the first week itself.

Peace, brother

Seagate has tied up with the National Insurance Company (NIC) in India for 'Peace of Mind'—an insurance policy for new PCs with a Seagate hard disk that will cover a wide range of computer components, regardless of the brand.

However, it does not cover the PC's plastic casing, mouse, keyboard and any other external peripherals.

Lately, resellers and customers have been complaining

about the higher failure rate of Seagate drives and 'Peace of Mind' seems to be a part of its effort to clean up its act.

Under this three-year insurance policy, consumers will be reimbursed for repair or replacement of parts, regardless of whether the PC is branded or assembled. Currently, VMS India Ltd has been appointed as the one point contact for registering the policy as well as claim related queries.



Spam

Spam's the name

It's official, and its true—it may soon be illegal to use the term spam, at least for Seattle based company, SpamArrest. The name 'Spam' was copyrighted decades back by Hormel Foods, who package their version of pork with the same name.

Though spam has gained notoriety recently as unsolicited commercial e-mail, and most people would not immediately associate it with pork, Hormel isn't amused, and has filed a legal petition with the US Patent and Trademark Office to desist SpamArrest. The spat started when SpamArrest, which specialises in blocking junk e-mail, decided to trademark its name. Hormel decided to fight back, claiming that the name was too close for comfort. However, legal analysts say that the case may not be as watertight as Hormel would like it to be.

Back at you

Anti-spam activists are having a field day plastering New Zealander, Steve Atkinson's address and personal details all over the Web. Atkinson, the man behind the spam that promoted male potency products, reportedly sent close to 100 million messages a day before a newspaper article revealed his personal details. He has now been spammed back by frustrated victims with a vengeance—his servers were forcibly relocated to another network, and he has decided to get out of the spam business.

■ The safety monitoring system of USA's David-Besse nuclear power plant was disabled for over five hours due to the Slammer worm attack